

Flower visualiser

There are many visualisers available for your Last.fm history. One of the better ones is hosted at www.diametunim.com/muse/, all you need to key in is any username

Piratebay uses Last.fm

Many web sites use Last.fm's rich database and API as a back-end, including Piratebay for tagging all the torrents listed in the music section

Geek life

bian phone, the easiest way to scrobble is to use a software known as Mobblor. Mobblor is not a plug-in for the existing MP3 player on your phone, but rather a player in itself. You can set Mobblor to scrobble tracks as and when you listen to them, or scrobble them all together after listening to a few tracks. Mobblor has the additional functionality of being able to stream music from Last.fm, though this will reflect heavily in your bills. Mobblor also lets you love or hate tracks, as well as skip and ban tracks if you are streaming music from Last.fm.

There are a number of language packs for Mobblor, including Pirate, 1337 and Klingon. Windows Mobile users have a number of options to scrobble. The simplest software that can be used is Pocket Scrobblor, which is mostly a background process. It logs the songs that are played from the default Windows Media Player already installed by default on your Windows Mobile OS.

Pocket Scrobblor is not a stand alone application, and cannot play music by itself. You need the .NET Compact Framework 2.0 installed on your Windows Mobile device in order to use Pocket Scrobblor. There is no free application to scrobble from a BlackBerry. There is an application known as Flip Side, that plays as well as scrobbles from a BlackBerry. Flip Side is also available as a purchase to Windows Mobile users. Flip Side is a standalone player, with a sleek touch interface.

There are scrobblers available for most major platforms, the glaring exception being scrobblers for Sony-Ericsson devices. Scrobbling support for this platform is on the agenda though, and should be around soon.

GET CRACKING WITH AUDIOSCROBBLER

If you need to scrobble from a particular source, but there is no current way to do so, you can make your own scrobblor using Last.fm's open API. All you really need to do is collect the metadata information, attribute a time-stamp, and pass it on to Last.fm in the specified format. The API is available at www.last.fm/api. Most of the scrobbling mechanisms above have been coded by Last.fm users who found a gap in scrobbling that they wanted to fill. A great place to start would be a Java app for mobile phones.

Scrobbling from web sites

Many web 2.0 music streaming sites such as YouScrobble and Lala already offer scrobbling to Last.fm as a feature. Although the Grooveshark community is demanding scrobbling support, there is no mechanism yet. To scrobble from Grooveshark, a Java application known as Rumpus can be used. Rumpus is available at <http://rumpus.altervista.org>, download the ZIP file and unpack it to a convenient folder. Removing the version number from the folder will help in the command line operation to follow. Go to Start > Run > CMD (the Windows console) and navigate to the Rumpus folder within the console. Then type in `Java -jar Rumpus.jar`. If a window does not pop up, make sure Java is installed properly on your machine. Enter in your Grooveshark username, and your Last.fm login details to continue.

Rumpus uses the RSS feed of the music that you listen to, generated by Grooveshark to submit to Last.fm. How often your Last.fm scrobbles get updated depends on how frequently your Grooveshark RSS feed gets updated,

which means that Last.fm will not show the "listening now" icon on your profile. You will have to listen to a few songs before the scrobbles start showing up on Last.fm (4 tracks, in our case). We also noticed a 50 minute lag in the timings

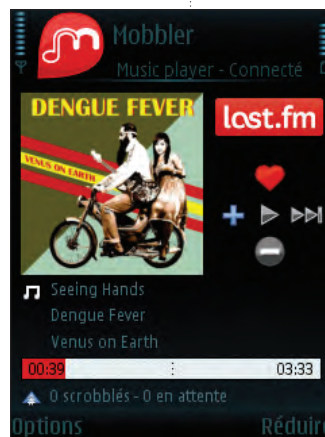
of the scrobbed tracks.

You can use an RSS feed reader to monitor your feed in Grooveshark, and then choose to scrobble many tracks at once. Your Grooveshark RSS feed is at http://api.grooveshark.com/feeds/1.0/users/<username>/recent_listens.rss. Rumpus automatically checks for updates to the RSS feed once it is running.

Scrobbling for YouTube works only on Firefox, through the popular Greasemonkey plugin.

If you don't have Greasemonkey, install it, and also install the Youscrobblor script (not to be confused with the YouScrobblor web site). The Youscrobblor script is available at <http://bit.ly/yscrlr>. Once the script is loaded, go to YouTube. Next to History and Subscriptions, there will now be a Scrobble button, along with the Last.fm logo.

Every time you watch a music video, you can click on the Scrobble button to relay the track information to Last.fm. The first time you click on the Scrobble button, you will be asked for your Last.fm login details. By default, the script expects the videos to be named in the `<artist> - <track name>` format. If this is not the format followed, you can edit the track names, and scrobble. You can use this script to scrobble any tracks, as a last resort to record a particular track in your library. Be careful of overusing this method though, as scrobble spamming is a bannable offence on Last.fm. 



Streaming Last.fm radio and scrobbling from Mobblor

ROCKBOX THE OPEN SOURCE PMP FIRMWARE

RockBox is an Open Source firmware for PMPs that is an alternative to the default firmware in your devices. RockBox allows you to exploit all the performance benefits of your device on a hardware level, while removing the restrictions imposed by manufacturers on a software level. RockBox is available for many devices, including devices manufactured by Apple, Sandisk and Cowon. There are unstable, but pretty usable ports for Samsung and Toshiba, and developers are working on a RockBox version for Philips. RockBox allows users to scrobble from their devices as easily as scrobbling from iPods, as well as a number of options, including skins. You will find all the usable ports on our DVD.